
**Unit 1, Option F,
Topic F7: From
Second Reich
to Third Reich:
Germany, 1918-45**

The focus of this topic is on the dramatic developments in Germany from the last months of the Hohenzollern Empire amidst defeat in the First World War to the ruin of the Third Reich in the rubble of defeat in the Second World War. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of nationalism and the exercise of power within Germany during these crucial 27 years. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the impact of war might draw on bullet points 1 and 4, one on the impact of economic difficulties might draw on bullet points 2 and 3.

The first bullet point relates to events between the summer of 1918 and October 1929. Students should understand how and why the Second Reich tried first to reform itself and then collapsed in November 1918. They should understand the framing of the Weimar constitution in 1919, the challenges the young republic faced from the forces of the extreme left and extreme right and the unfavourable conditions created by the Treaty of Versailles and escalating inflation. They should appreciate the importance of Stresemann first as Chancellor and then as Foreign Minister in rescuing the Republic in 1923-24 and the emergence of some degree of prosperity and stability in the next five years.

The second bullet point relates to the formation and development of the National Socialist German Workers' Party (NSDAP) as a serious threat to the stability of the republic. Students should understand the pattern of its development and in particular the reasons for the rapid growth in electoral support after 1928. They should be aware of opposing parties and why ultimately the opponents of the NSDAP failed to stop Hitler's appointment as Chancellor in January 1933.

The third bullet point relates to the Third Reich between 1933 and 1941. Students should be aware of the salient features of Nazi social and economic policies, in particular the determination to prepare Germany for war and to create the Volksgemeinschaft. They should be aware of how this latter aim translated into the escalating persecution of minorities, in particular the Jews. The policies of the Nazi regime regarding women, children and education should also be studied.

The fourth bullet point relates to the downfall of the Third Reich. Students will not require a detailed knowledge of the campaigns of the Second World War but they should understand something of the impact of the war on Germany and on the lives of its citizens and the reasons for Germany's ultimate defeat.